



FOCUS ON... SODIUM

The use of sodium dates back thousands of years.



▲ Ancient Egyptians used a sodium compound, natron, to preserve mummies.



▲ Sodium chloride, or common salt, adds flavour to foods.



▲ Sodium compounds give some fireworks their yellow colour.

Sodium

11
Na

The most common alkali metal in Earth's crust, sodium is purified by electrifying sodium chloride. The electric current splits the sodium and chlorine apart in a process known as electrolysis.

ATOMIC MASS 22.99

STATE Solid

DISCOVERY 1807 (Sir Humphry Davy)

**Nugget of
pure sodium**



Potassium

19
K

This metal helps the nerves and muscles in the body work properly. Potassium is found in foods such as bananas and avocados. Its compounds are used in soaps, plant fertilizers, and gunpowder.

ATOMIC MASS 39.098

STATE Solid

DISCOVERY 1807 (Sir Humphry Davy)

*A layer of
dark oxide
covers the
outside of
the metal.*

*Pure
potassium*

**Nugget of
potassium**

